Now, soon after introducing himself, Pal sat opposite my bed and asked: 'Who is Madhu?'

I could not remember the name instantly. And then it came to me.

'Madhu, is an attendant at the Liquid Propulsion Systems Centre where I worked.'

A casual staff, Madhu was a young and energetic man with ten years in ISRO. He was mostly attached to my office. I asked Pal why he asked about Madhu.

'No, nothing … I just wanted your opinion on him.'

I said he was an honest and hardworking employee. Later that night Pal would explain to me the reason behind his query: the IB had stated in its report that Madhu carried the 'documents' to my car, and my driver Sukumaran took them somewhere.

Now I remembered one of those IB men telling me that my office assistant and driver had 'confessed' to the crime of carting away state secrets from ISRO. Those monsters would have tortured my poor guys to 'confess', I thought. I was furious.

I was partly wrong. Pal told me that the IB men tried their best, but both Madhu and Sukumar maintained there was no wrong doing.

'Hats off to Madhu,' Pal said. 'He stuck to his statement till the end that Nambi Narayanan never used to take any documents home. At one point, the lad told the investigators that if they wanted him to say that Nambi did take documents, he would do that, but he would also add that what he said just now was a lie. The IB officials were stunned by the man's conviction that you can do no wrong. Driver Sukumaran also stuck to the statement.'

Pal had evidently questioned Madhu and Sukumaran—and many others—and was by now convinced of the IB fabrication.

There was an hour's break when I returned to my room. When called back, I found Surendra Pal and P C Sharma, with them Ahmed, the managing director of Hotel Fort Manor, Trivandrum. Ahmed was known to me as he played host to ISRO guests, especially Russian scientists who visited our centre in Trivandrum as part of the cryogenics project.